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A BIRD BOOK

The Road Was Already There

How Ecosystems Create Entrepreneurs



DHARMENDRA SATAPATHY



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For every distributor who spent years
building a road before the journey
— and for the ones who will not have to.

The Road Was Already There
How Ecosystems Create Entrepreneurs

© Dharmendra Satapathy. A BIRD Book. BIRD stands for Build, Innovate, Reimagine, Delegate.

Ramesh, whose road runs through this book, is a composite. His story draws on patterns common among Indian mutual fund distributors, not on any one person.

All figures in this book are illustrative. They are used to explain principles, not to describe any particular business, product or investment. Nothing in this book is investment advice.

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PROLOGUE

Two Entrepreneurs. Two Different Worlds.

Two entrepreneurs have the same ambition. Each wants to manufacture a product and sell it throughout the country.

Their ideas are equally promising. Neither lacks determination, intelligence or the willingness to take risks. Yet their prospects are very different.

The first entrepreneur must operate in an economy where the facilities required to do business are poorly developed. He must find suppliers, arrange transportation, establish warehouses, organise distribution, develop payment arrangements, acquire technology and reach customers. Before he can concentrate on selling his product, he must solve an extraordinary number of surrounding problems.

The second entrepreneur faces a different situation. Suppliers can be found through established networks. Warehousing is available. Logistics companies transport goods. Digital payments are widely accessible. Technology can be obtained as a service. Platforms connect businesses with customers.

The difference is not entrepreneurial ability. It is the environment in which entrepreneurship takes place.

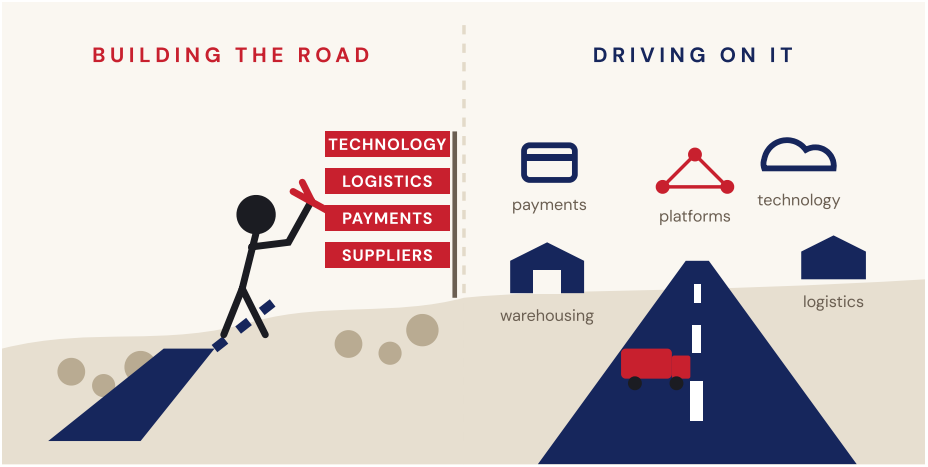


ILLUSTRATION 1 The two entrepreneurs. One must construct the road before he can begin. The other begins on a road someone else has built: warehouses, logistics, payments, platforms and technology already in place.

One entrepreneur must construct the road before he can begin his journey. The other begins his journey on a road someone else has constructed.

This difference has far-reaching consequences. It affects the amount of capital required to start a business, the risks an entrepreneur must assume, the speed at which an enterprise can grow and the number of people who can realistically become entrepreneurs.

It also raises a fascinating question. What happens when entrepreneurs begin creating the very systems that make entrepreneurship easier for others? This book explores that question. Its central proposition is simple:

THE PROPOSITION OF THIS BOOK

Entrepreneurs once had to build much of the ecosystem required for their businesses. Today, ecosystems increasingly help create entrepreneurs.

And those who construct the roads used by thousands of other businesses may occupy a particularly important place in the economy.

At the heart of this book is a pyramid. At its apex is the customer. Beneath the customer stands the practitioner who serves them, and beneath the practitioner, the business that practitioner builds. That business rests on suppliers and vendors, on platforms built for its trade, on platforms built for everyone, and finally on government and the institutions that create confidence. Every chapter that follows is about one part of that pyramid: what it costs when a layer is missing, what becomes possible when it is present, and what happens when you decide to build a layer for others.

RAMESH'S ROAD · 1

A scooter and a bag of forms

To see what this means for a mutual fund distributor, we will follow one through this book. His name is Ramesh.

2001. Ramesh leaves a bank job in Pune to become a mutual fund distributor. His office is a table in his front room. His infrastructure is a scooter, a box of application forms from six fund houses and a diary of phone numbers.

Every investment is a small expedition. He fills the form at the client's home, collects a cheque and photocopies of documents, rides to the fund house or the registrar's service centre, and returns a week later if a signature does not match. Statements arrive by post. When a client asks how their money is doing, Ramesh adds it up by hand.

He is good at his work. Clients trust him. They tell their friends. But almost all of his day is spent making investing *possible*, and very little of it on the advice his clients actually come to him for.

Ramesh is the first entrepreneur in the story above. He is building the road himself.

PART I

The Cost of Building Everything

Every business carries two bills: the cost of doing the work, and the cost of making the work possible.

CHAPTER 1

The Business Behind the Business

What does it really take to become an entrepreneur?

We usually think of an idea, some capital, the willingness to take risks and the determination to succeed. But these are only part of the story. Every business depends on capabilities beyond the product or service it offers.

THE DOCTOR AND THE CLINIC

A doctor, for example, may wish to establish a clinic. The doctor's principal contribution is medical expertise. Patients come for diagnosis, treatment and professional judgment.

Yet the clinic also requires premises, equipment, medicines, diagnostic facilities, patient records, electricity, administrative assistance and payment arrangements.

When they are not available, the doctor must find ways to create them. A laboratory may need to be established. Medicines may need to be stocked. Equipment maintenance must be arranged. Administrative procedures must be developed independently. The best diagnostician in town becomes, without ever choosing to, the manager of a small and badly run laboratory.

THE DISTRIBUTOR AND THE PAPERWORK

Now consider a mutual fund distributor.

Today an investor can complete KYC digitally, register a mandate online and invest through a platform in minutes. The registrars keep the records. The platforms carry the transactions. The banking system moves the money. The dis-

tributor has not become less important. The distributor has become free to do the important part.

TWO COSTS, NOT ONE

This reveals two distinct costs.

The first is the cost of providing a service. The second is the cost of making that service possible.

Where the surrounding ecosystem is weak, entrepreneurs must shoulder more of both. Where the ecosystem is developed, many supporting capabilities can be obtained from others. The difference can transform the economics of an enterprise.

Notice that the second cost is easy to mistake for the first. A practitioner who has spent twenty years doing both may honestly believe the paperwork *is* the job. It is only when the surrounding machinery improves that the true shape of the work becomes visible, and with it, how much of the practitioner's life was spent on the road rather than the journey.

> THE FIRST PRINCIPLE
>
> **The cost of entrepreneurship is not merely the cost of the business. It also includes the cost of the ecosystem the business cannot yet access.**

FOR YOUR PRACTICE

1. List everything you did last week. Which hours went to the service itself, and which went to making the service possible?

CHAPTER 2

The Expense Nobody Sees

Suppose 100 entrepreneurs each require a particular technology system. There is no common provider. Consequently, every entrepreneur develops a separate solution.

If each system costs ₹10 lakh, the total investment becomes ₹10 crore.

Now imagine that a specialist can develop one shared solution for ₹50 lakh and offer it to all 100 businesses through annual subscriptions. The individual entrepreneurs no longer need to finance separate development projects. The specialist receives subscription revenue. The businesses preserve capital. And resources that would otherwise have been committed to duplicated systems become available for other uses.

A common capability can sometimes replace hundreds of separate investments.

THE HIDDEN TAX ON ENTREPRENEURSHIP

The absence of such capabilities imposes a cost that is rarely identified explicitly. We might call it the *hidden tax on entrepreneurship*. It is not a government tax. It is the economic burden created when essential supporting facilities do not exist.

- Without dependable roads, businesses must make additional transportation arrangements.
- Without established payment systems, they must devise alternative ways to receive money.
- Without reliable identity verification, they must devote more effort to confirming whom they are dealing with.
- Without specialised vendors, they must perform more functions themselves.

The hidden tax is also regressive. A large company can absorb it. A small entrepreneur cannot. So when the ecosystem is weak, scale itself becomes the entry ticket, and the market belongs to those who are already big.

THE BUSINESSES THAT NEVER BEGIN

As the obstacles accumulate, some potential entrepreneurs decide that the investment is too large or the risks too great. Others may never seriously consider starting. The economic loss therefore extends beyond the additional expenses incurred by existing enterprises. It includes businesses that never come into existence.

MODEL 1 **The Hidden Cost of Entry**

TOTAL ENTREPRENEURIAL BURDEN

=	**Core Business Investment**
+	Cost of Missing Infrastructure
+	Cost of Missing Capabilities
+	Cost of Establishing Trust
+	Cost of Coordination

As the ecosystem develops, several of these additional burdens can decline. Only the first is truly the entrepreneur's own.

RAMESH'S ROAD · 2 **The week he counted**

2008. Ramesh now looks after about 300 families. He has rented a small office and hired two assistants, both of whom spend their days on forms, couriers, cheque deposits and follow-ups with service centres.

One week, on a friend's advice, he writes down where his hours go. Of roughly 60 hours, about 35 went to the machinery: checking forms, chasing signatures, answering "has my money been invested?", reconciling statements. About 25 went to clients: understanding their goals, explaining a fall in the market, planning a daughter's education.

Put through Model 1, his burden is plain. His core business is advice. But he is also paying for missing infrastructure (the scooter, the couriers),

missing capabilities (two salaries for paperwork), trust (every client must meet him personally before investing) and coordination (six fund houses, each with its own forms).

Ramesh's ceiling is not his skill. It is the road. With this much of his week spent building it, he cannot take on many more families, however good his advice.

FOR YOUR PRACTICE

1. Using Model 1, estimate what you spend each year on the four burdens that are not your core business.

PART II

The Rise of Enablement

The important change is not that resources became free. It is the difference between having to own a capability and being able to access it.

CHAPTER 3

Own the Journey, Access the Road

An economy becomes more capable as people and organisations develop specialised expertise. Some become skilled at moving goods. Others provide warehousing, accounting, software, payments, distribution or professional services. Still others create marketplaces through which independent participants can find one another.

OWNING VERSUS ACCESSING

A technology entrepreneur can launch an application without constructing a data centre. A small merchant can accept digital payments without establishing a payment network. A manufacturer can distribute products without purchas-

ing a fleet of vehicles. A distributor can transact for clients across the country through a platform without opening a branch in every city.

The transformation lies in the difference between having to own a capability and being able to access it.

This can turn a large initial investment into a recurring or usage-linked expense. Instead of raising capital for a system before the first customer arrives, the entrepreneur pays as customers arrive. Cost begins to follow revenue rather than run ahead of it. It can also allow entrepreneurs to begin operating at a smaller scale.

THE GIFT OF FOCUS

Most importantly, it lets them focus. Doctors can devote more attention to patients. Educators can concentrate on teaching. Financial advisers can spend more time understanding investors.

Focus compounds. The adviser who spends an extra hour a day with investors builds deeper relationships, better judgment and a stronger reputation. Time released from road-building is reinvested in the very skill that makes the practitioner valuable.

> THE SECOND PRINCIPLE
>
> **The more developed the ecosystem, the less an entrepreneur needs to build before beginning to create value.**

WHAT TO OWN, AND WHAT TO ACCESS

Does this capability create value because we own it, or because we can use it effectively?

A useful way to sort the answer is in three groups.

Own it

What makes clients choose you: your relationships, your brand, your judgment, your way of serving, and the operating system that holds them together, mean-

ing the way your business actually runs. These are the business. Hand them to someone else and there is nothing left to build.

Access it

What every competitor needs equally and nobody wins on: transaction processing, record-keeping, payment collection, routine compliance. Doing these yourself makes you busier, not better.

Access it, but watch it

What you need from outside but cannot afford to lose: a critical platform, a key data source, a channel that brings most of your clients. Use it, but keep a plan for the day it changes. Chapter 16 returns to this.

THE THIRD PRINCIPLE

The modern entrepreneur need not own every capability. But must understand which capabilities are too important to leave entirely in someone else's hands.

FOR YOUR PRACTICE

1. Sort ten capabilities your business uses into *own*, *access* and *access but watch*.

CHAPTER 4 · THE HEART OF THE BOOK

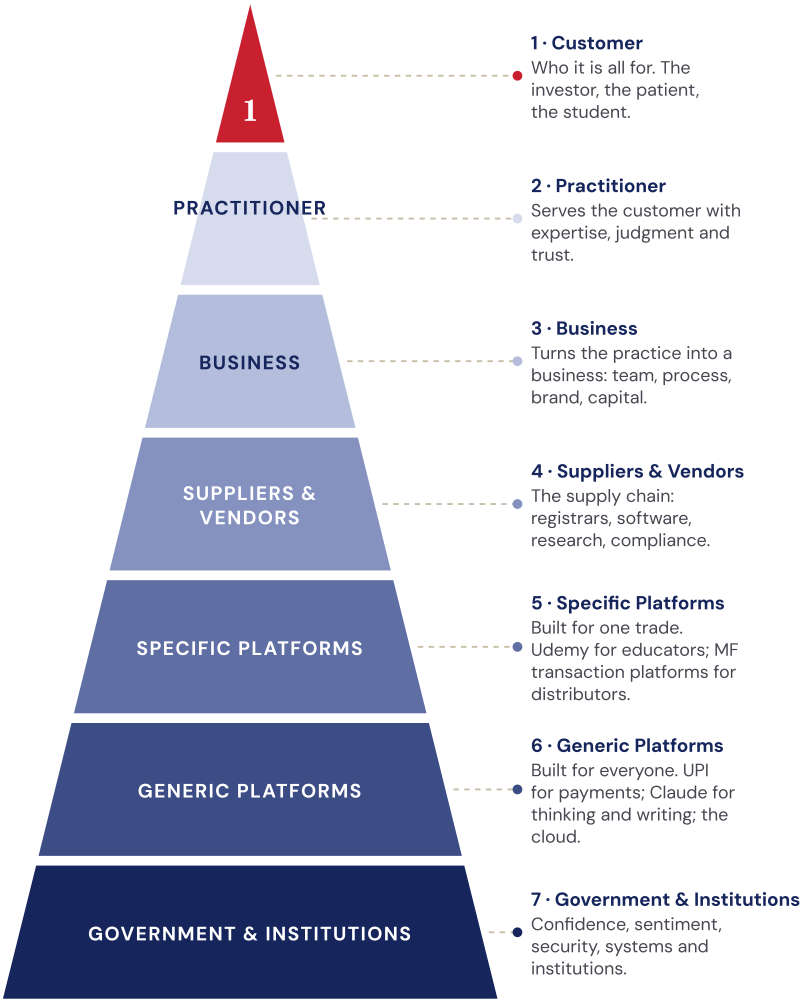
The Enablement Pyramid

Every business begins with a customer who wants something. The patient wants treatment. The investor wants financial security. The student wants education. Someone must meet that need.

MODEL 2

The Enablement Pyramid

WHO IT IS ALL FOR



THE FOUNDATION

each layer enables the one above it

Read it from the top down to see who serves whom. Read it from the bottom up to see what makes the service possible.

1 · The customer

The apex, and the reason the whole structure exists. The investor who wants to retire with dignity, the parent saving for a child's education. Every layer below is judged, in the end, by what reaches this person.

2 · The practitioner

The one who serves the customer: the doctor, the teacher, the mutual fund distributor. The practitioner brings expertise, judgment and trust. At the start of a career, the practitioner usually stands almost directly on the lower layers, carrying everything in between personally.

3 · The business

Sooner or later the practitioner turns the practice into a business: a team, processes, a brand, capital. The business multiplies what the practitioner can do. This is the layer most distributors are trying to build, and the one this book cares about most.

4 · Suppliers and vendors

No business builds everything. Beneath it runs a supply chain of specialised services: registrars who keep records, software providers, research houses, compliance professionals, printers, couriers, accountants. Each one is a piece of road the business does not have to lay.

5 · Specific platforms

Below the vendors are platforms built for one trade. Udemy gives an educator a classroom, a payment counter and a worldwide audience without a single rented room. Mutual fund transaction platforms give a distributor the ability to transact with every fund house from one screen. A specific platform knows the needs of its trade and builds them in once, for everyone in it.

6 · Generic platforms

Below those are platforms built for everyone, whatever their trade. UPI lets a street vendor and a wealth firm collect money the same way. An AI assistant such as Claude helps a one-person practice draft, analyse and explain as if it

had a back office. The cloud, messaging, digital identity: generic platforms are the shared rails on which every specific platform and every business runs.

7 · Government and institutions

At the base, holding up everything, is government. It provides what no business can provide for itself: **confidence** that the future will allow enterprise, **sentiment** that encourages people to invest and to start, **security** of life, property and contracts, **systems** such as identity, courts and regulation, and the **institutions** that make all of these dependable. Chapter 5 shows how much of this is trust.

Every layer exists so that someone above it can serve the customer.

THE PYRAMID BEHIND ONE SIP

When a monthly SIP is debited on the fifth of every month for twenty years without the investor ever thinking about it, the whole pyramid has done its job. A distributor advised it. A firm recorded and reviewed it. A registrar holds the units. A transaction platform carried the instruction. Payment rails moved the money. Identity systems confirmed the investor, and a regulator stood behind the rules. The investor sees one person. The person stands on six layers.

THREE WAYS TO USE THE PYRAMID

To see what you carry. Wherever a layer beneath you is missing or weak, you are carrying it yourself. That is the hidden tax of Chapter 2.

To see what you can stand on. Every layer that exists is a road you need not build. That is the subject of Chapter 3.

To see what you could build. Every layer was built by someone. A practitioner who builds a business has added a layer. One who builds a vendor service or a platform for other practitioners has moved further down the pyramid, closer to the foundations, and widened its reach. That is the journey of Parts IV and V and Chapter 17.

FOR YOUR PRACTICE

1. Draw the pyramid for your own practice. Name at least one organisation in each layer.

CHAPTER 5

How Strangers Learned to Trust One Another

Consider a manufacturer and a supplier who have never met. The manufacturer needs materials. The supplier is willing to provide them. But willingness alone does not complete a transaction. Both parties need confidence.

- Who is the other party? What exactly will be delivered?
- When must payment be made? What standards determine acceptable quality?
- What happens if either party fails? How will a disagreement be resolved?

Without reliable answers, transactions become uncertain and costly. Businesses must depend heavily on personal relationships. For centuries that is exactly how commerce worked. Credit moved along chains of community and family. It worked, and it still works, but it has a ceiling. You can only know so many people.

Trust can move from being primarily personal to being supported by institutions and systems.

FIVE MECHANISMS OF TRUST

Identity. PAN, KYC procedures and permitted Aadhaar-based verification establish who participants are. A fund house can accept money from an investor it has never seen because the system has already answered the question *who is this?*

Contracts. Enforceable agreements specify responsibilities and remedies. A written promise that a court will uphold is worth more than a spoken one between strangers.

Protocols. Shared operating rules let different systems exchange information and transact. When a payment moves instantly between two different banks, a protocol, not a relationship, made it possible.

Dispute resolution. Courts, arbitration and regulatory mechanisms provide formal ways to address disagreements. People take risks more readily when there is a fair way out.

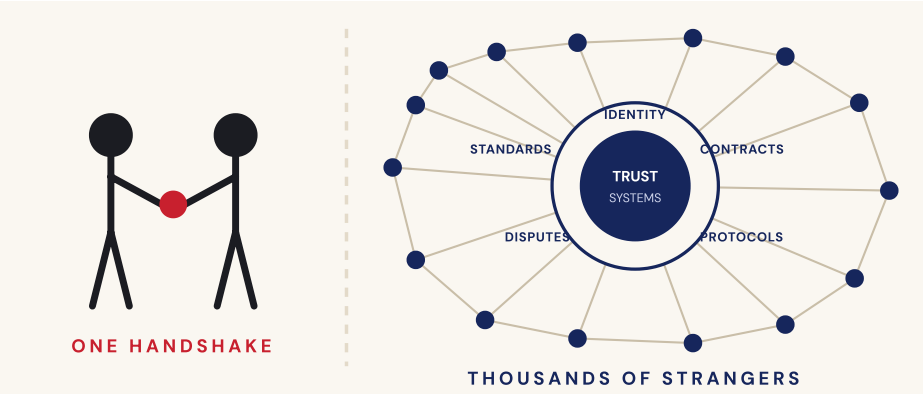


ILLUSTRATION 3 From handshakes to systems. Personal trust connects two people. Identity, contracts, standards, protocols and dispute resolution connect thousands who will never meet.

None of this makes personal trust obsolete. An investor still chooses an adviser because of who that adviser is. But system trust removes the need to rebuild confidence for every transaction, so that personal trust can be spent where it matters most: on judgment, not paperwork.

THE FOURTH PRINCIPLE

Trust is the invisible infrastructure that allows economic relationships to scale beyond personal relationships.

THE CONFIDENCE INSTITUTIONS CREATE

Governments contribute roads, ports and electricity. They also contribute something less tangible: confidence in the future. Entrepreneurs invest, hire and borrow because they believe the environment will let them operate tomorrow. Predictable laws, effective courts and credible regulation all feed that belief.

For a distributor, regulation is easy to see only as a cost. But credible regulation is also part of the road. Investors put their savings into mutual funds partly because they trust that the money is held safely, that the rules are enforced and that disclosures mean something. Every distributor who explains a fund to a first-time investor is drawing on confidence built over decades by institutions the distributor did not create.

THE FIFTH PRINCIPLE

Infrastructure makes entrepreneurship possible. Institutional confidence makes entrepreneurs more willing to act.

RAMESH'S ROAD · 3

The road arrives, and a new trap

2012–2020. Over a few years the road is built around Ramesh. His clients complete KYC digitally. Transactions go through exchange platforms and online fund-house portals. Mandates replace post-dated cheques. Consolidated statements show a client's holdings across fund houses in one place.

In the language of Chapter 4, the lower layers of Ramesh's pyramid have filled in: specific platforms for his trade, generic rails for payments and identity, and institutions that investors trust.

Ramesh's paperwork hours fall from about 35 a week to under 10. He accesses what he once had to build, exactly as Chapter 3 describes. One assistant moves into client servicing.

But Ramesh fills the freed hours with more of the same. He takes on more families, now about 600, and handles every one of them himself.

Clients call his mobile, not the office. They trust *Ramesh*, not the firm. The system now carries their trust in the transaction; nothing yet carries their trust in the advice except Ramesh himself.

The road outside his office is finished. The road inside it has not been started.

FOR YOUR PRACTICE

1. Where does your business still rely only on personal trust? What would break if you doubled your clients tomorrow?

PART III

The Economics of Sharing

The shared road does more than improve existing journeys. It makes additional journeys possible.

CHAPTER 6

Why One Highway Can Be Better Than a Hundred Roads

Imagine a manufacturing region where businesses need access to a large market. If each enterprise must construct its own route, the investment burden becomes enormous. A common road changes the situation. Its construction requires capital, but the same road can serve thousands of businesses. The investment is shared among users and, where relevant, taxpayers.

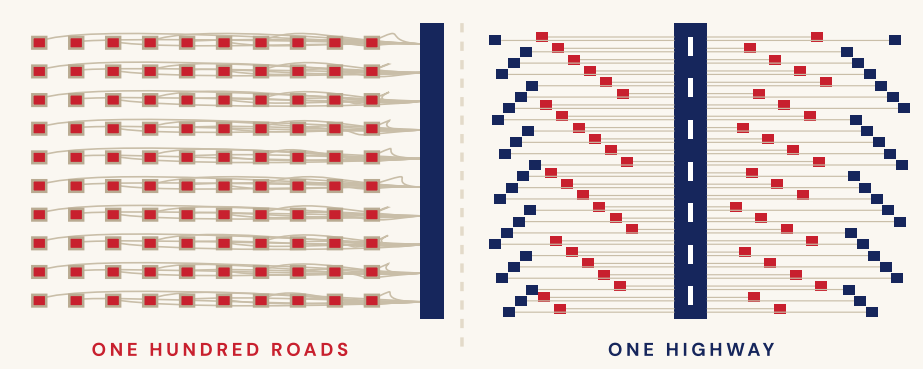


ILLUSTRATION 4 One hundred roads or one highway? A hundred businesses each building a separate route to market, against a single highway that serves them all.

THREE MECHANISMS

Economies of scale distribute certain costs across a greater volume of activity. A system that costs the same to build whether it serves ten users or ten thousand becomes cheaper per user with every user who joins.

Specialisation lets dedicated providers develop expertise that individual businesses struggle to reproduce. A firm that does nothing but run a registry or a payment rail learns things no part-time builder ever will.

Resource sharing lets many users benefit from common facilities without owning complete systems. The warehouse that is half empty for one merchant is full for twenty.

WHEN SHARING DOES NOT WIN

Shared provision is not cheaper in every situation. Congestion, service quality, operating expenses, coordination costs and provider margins must be considered. A shared highway at rush hour can be slower than a private lane. The advantage exists when shared provision delivers an appropriate level of service at a lower overall cost, after allowing for risk and quality.

MODEL 3 **The Economics of Shared Infrastructure**

INDEPENDENT MODEL

100 businesses × ₹10 lakh each

₹10 crore

initial investment, duplicated a hundred times

SHARED MODEL

One common infrastructure investment

₹50 lakh

each business pays an access fee

The shared model wins when total access and operating costs, adjusted for service quality and risk, are lower than the independent alternative.

All figures are illustrative.

The shared road does more than improve existing journeys. It makes additional journeys possible.

A HUNDRED PRACTICES, ONE BACK OFFICE

Now look at distribution through this lens. In any large city there are dozens of small practices, each building the same things alone: an operations desk, a way to onboard clients, a review format, a compliance file, a training routine for a new hire. Each pays for its own version, usually under-used and rarely excellent. That is a hundred roads. Chapter 17 asks who will build the highway.

FOR YOUR PRACTICE

1. Which costs in your practice are you duplicating with every other practice in your city?

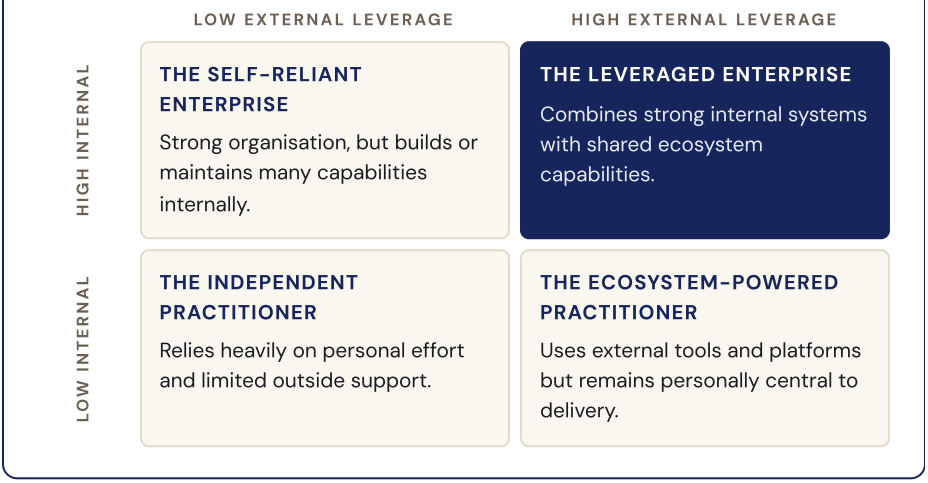
CHAPTER 7

Two Ways to Multiply an Entrepreneur's Capacity

Entrepreneurship offers a way beyond that limit. The entrepreneur organises people, capital, processes, technology and management. These multiply what can be accomplished within the enterprise. This is **internal leverage**.

A developed ecosystem provides another possibility. The enterprise can use vendors, platforms, infrastructure, standards and institutions created by others. This is **external leverage**.

MODEL 4 **The Leverage Matrix**



THE FOUR JOURNEYS

Each quadrant has its own trap. The **independent practitioner** works hardest of all and is capped by personal hours. The **ecosystem-powered practitioner** has better tools but is still the bottleneck: every client still needs the founder. The **self-reliant enterprise** has a team but spends its strength rebuilding what

the market already offers. Only the **leveraged enterprise** uses both levers at once.

Most practices first move rightwards: adopting a platform costs less than building a team. The upward step is harder and more valuable. It requires delegation, process and a second line of leadership.

Internal leverage multiplies what you build. External leverage multiplies what you can access.

RAMESH'S ROAD · 4

The upward step

2021. Placed on Model 4, Ramesh sees himself clearly. He started in the bottom-left. The industry's new road moved him right, to the ecosystem-powered practitioner. He is still the bottleneck. He has not taken a holiday longer than four days in years.

So he works on the upward step. He hires a relationship manager and gives her a defined set of families. He writes down how a portfolio review is done, so it is done the same way whoever does it. He moves client records into a CRM that belongs to his firm. He gives the practice a name of its own, so that clients begin to say they invest "with the firm" rather than "with Ramesh".

He also sorts his capabilities using Chapter 3. He *owns* client relationships, the review method and the brand. He *accesses* transaction platforms, registrars and research. He *accesses but watches* the one platform through which most of his transactions now flow.

It is slower and more uncomfortable than adding clients. It is also the first time his business has grown without his hours growing with it.

FOR YOUR PRACTICE

1. Which quadrant are you in today? Be honest about where the work actually depends on you.

PART IV

The Entrepreneurial Multiplier

Entrepreneurs create ecosystems. Ecosystems create more entrepreneurs.

CHAPTER 8

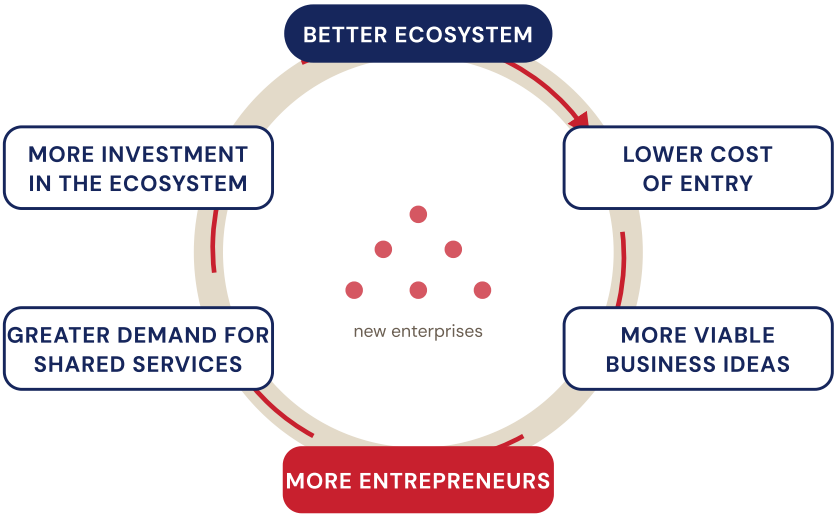
The Cycle That Creates More Entrepreneurs

Imagine a region that develops a dependable logistics network. Small businesses can now reach customers beyond their immediate surroundings. Some begin selling in new markets. Others launch products that would previously have been difficult to distribute.

Digital payments in India are a vivid example. As more merchants accepted them, more customers used them. As more customers used them, more merchants had a reason to accept them, and a generation of businesses grew up assuming that collecting money would be easy.

Entrepreneurs create ecosystems. Ecosystems create more entrepreneurs.

MODEL 5 **The Entrepreneurial Multiplier**



The cycle is potentially self-reinforcing, but it is not automatic.

WHAT MAKES THE CYCLE TURN, OR STALL

Its effectiveness depends on demand, competition, institutions, capital and talent. Poor infrastructure, excessive charges, monopolistic behaviour or restrictive rules can weaken it. A road with a toll too high is a road few will use. When conditions are favourable, the ecosystem does not merely improve existing enterprises. It increases the number of enterprises that are economically possible.

The same cycle works inside a profession. As digital onboarding and platforms spread through distribution, it became possible to start a practice with far less capital and administration than Ramesh needed in 2001. More people could become distributors, which in turn drew more investment into the platforms and tools that serve them. A profession whose members share their roads grows faster than one where every member builds alone.

FOR YOUR PRACTICE

1. Which part of your profession's ecosystem has improved most in the last ten years? Who started that cycle?

CHAPTER 9

From Serving People to Enabling Those Who Serve

Consider three entrepreneurs in healthcare. The first is a successful doctor. The second builds a hospital employing 100 doctors. The third develops a system that helps thousands of hospitals manage records, appointments, procurement and administration.

The same progression exists in financial services. An individual distributor serves investors. A wealth management firm enables several advisers to serve investors. A transaction platform supports many distributors and firms. Common identity and payment infrastructure supports entire categories of financial activity. The higher levels are further from the investor, yet their potential reach is much greater.

MODEL 6 **The Evolution of Entrepreneurial Reach**

PRACTITIONER	Creates value personally.
ENTERPRISE BUILDER	Enables employees to create value.
NETWORK BUILDER	Connects multiple businesses.
PLATFORM BUILDER	Enables participants to transact and scale.
ECOSYSTEM ENABLER	Creates conditions supporting entire categories of economic activity.

Model 6 is the Enablement Pyramid seen from the builder's side. The practitioner stands near the top, serving customers directly. Each step down the ladder builds a lower, broader layer of the pyramid, one that holds up more of the people above it.

Each step asks something different. Moving from practitioner to enterprise builder asks you to trust others with your clients. Moving to network builder asks you to work with people you do not employ. Moving to platform builder asks you to design rules and systems that work without you in the room. Each step trades a little personal control for a great deal of reach.

Not everyone needs to climb. But everyone should know which rung they are on, and whether that is a choice or simply where they stopped.

THE SIXTH PRINCIPLE

The scale of your contribution is not determined only by how many customers you serve. It can also depend on how many others you enable to serve customers.

FOR YOUR PRACTICE

1. Which rung of Model 6 are you on today? Which rung do you want to be on in ten years?

CHAPTER 10

Why Enablement Can Become Valuable

A platform may support thousands of businesses. An infrastructure provider may facilitate millions of transactions. Does this automatically make the enabling organisation valuable? Not necessarily.

The commercial value of an enabling enterprise depends on whether it can capture a durable share of the value it helps create. Its business model must work. Its participants must keep finding it useful. Its costs must be controlled. Its position must withstand competition. Its future cash flows must justify the investment required.

PROFIT PROMISED IN ADVANCE

Valuation is profit promised in advance.

It is not profit guaranteed in advance. It is not money already earned. It is the present recognition of future economic expectations.

A buyer who pays for a business today is paying for the profits that business is expected to earn tomorrow. The more confident the buyer is that those profits will arrive, and keep arriving, the more the buyer will pay. A business that depends entirely on its founder's personal effort offers a short and uncertain promise. A business built on systems, a team and recurring relationships offers a longer one.

THE SEVENTH PRINCIPLE

The greatest commercial opportunity may lie not in participating in every transaction, but in building something valuable that makes many transactions possible.

RAMESH'S ROAD · 5

What is it worth without you?

2023. At a family wedding, an older distributor tells Ramesh he wants to retire but cannot find anyone to take over his practice. "Everything is in my head," he says. "Who would pay for that?"

Ramesh goes home and asks the same question of his own firm. If he stepped away for a year, what would still earn? Two years ago the honest answer was: very little. Today it is better. The relationship manager handles her families on her own. The review method is written down. The CRM belongs to the firm. The promise his business can make to a buyer, or to a successor, has grown longer.

He starts preparing a second line of leadership and keeps a simple record of what the firm would be worth on the day he chooses to step back, rather than leaving it to be discovered on a day he does not choose.

For the first time, Ramesh is building something whose value does not end with his working hours.

FOR YOUR PRACTICE

1. If someone offered to buy your practice tomorrow, what future profits would they be paying for? How confident could they be?

PART V

The Long Runway

Why the greatest brands of tomorrow may be built by those who build the roads.

CHAPTER 11

When Everyone Has the Road

There was a time when building a business meant building almost everything that supported it.

An entrepreneur who wanted to manufacture and sell soap, cosmetics, clothing or household products needed far more than a good product. He needed factories, warehouses, distribution networks, advertising agencies, training systems, financial arrangements, logistics and people. There was no ready ecosystem of specialised providers offering these capabilities at affordable prices. Much of it had to be created internally.

Naturally, only entrepreneurs with substantial capital, patience and organisational capability could undertake such an exercise. This gave large enterprises a tremendous advantage. Consumer companies such as Hindustan Unilever, Procter & Gamble and Colgate-Palmolive, like the great Indian business houses in their own industries, could invest in infrastructure that smaller competitors could not afford. Once established, that infrastructure became a formidable barrier.

Their size gave them efficiencies. Their efficiencies gave them staying power. Their staying power gave them time.

And time gave them the opportunity to build brands.

Brands such as Surf, Lifebuoy and Colgate did not become household names overnight. They entered homes, became part of routines, accompanied families through generations and gradually acquired emotional significance. Their greatest advantage was not merely advertising expenditure. It was the long runway over which advertising, experience, familiarity and trust could compound.

THE INFRASTRUCTURE REVOLUTION

Now consider what has happened since. A modern entrepreneur can use Canva for design, Shopify for commerce, cloud-based learning systems for education, logistics providers for distribution, specialised agencies for marketing and digital platforms for customer management. UPI makes payment convenient and widely accessible. He can subscribe to these systems, rent them or participate in them. What once required enormous capital expenditure can now often be accessed through modest operating expenditure.

Yesterday, entrepreneurs had to build the road before they could drive their cars. Today, the road is already there.

The benefits are substantial. Consumers enjoy greater choice. Price discovery improves. Experiments become cheap: an idea that once cost a year's savings to test can now be tried for a month's subscription. Innovation becomes accessible to smaller participants. Entrepreneurship becomes democratised.

But this democratisation has a consequence that deserves far greater attention.

When everyone can access the same road, merely being on the road is no longer a competitive advantage.

THE SHORTENING RUNWAY

Imagine an entrepreneur launching a new cosmetic brand. He can access professional design, contract manufacturing, digital advertising, e-commerce marketplaces, logistics and payment systems. Within a short period, he can present himself as a sophisticated consumer brand.

But his competitors can do exactly the same thing. A successful product can attract imitation rapidly. Customers can compare alternatives instantly. The entrepreneur may have less time to enjoy a distinctive advantage before it is challenged.

THE EIGHTH PRINCIPLE · THE SHORTENING RUNWAY

As entrepreneurial infrastructure becomes more accessible, the time required to launch a business falls, but so may the time during which its competitive advantages remain distinctive.

This does not mean every new consumer brand must fail, or that enduring brands can no longer be created. It means that the conditions under which yesterday's great brands were built have changed. A distributor sees the same thing: the platforms, onboarding and reports that freed Ramesh are available to every new practice in his city, so they no longer set him apart.

FOR YOUR PRACTICE

1. Which of your advantages could a new competitor rent tomorrow? Which could they not?

CHAPTER 12

Brands Need Time

A product can be launched in a few months. A name can become recognisable in a few years. But an enduring brand is something much deeper.

A brand becomes powerful when customers stop evaluating it purely through price, features and convenience. It becomes part of their lives. They remember it. They trust it. They associate it with experiences, people, occasions and emotions. This transformation requires repeated positive experiences over time.

For many families, Lifebuoy was not simply a soap. It represented cleanliness, protection and a familiar household ritual. Surf became associated with generations of domestic life and memorable advertising. These associations were accumulated over decades.

A brand is an emotional asset built through the compounding of familiarity, experience and trust.

Time is not sufficient to create this asset, but it is often an essential ingredient. And this is precisely where a shortening runway creates difficulty. When products change rapidly, competitors multiply and customers continuously switch between alternatives, the opportunity for emotional compounding may weaken. Customers remain rational buyers for longer. A business may achieve sales, recognition and even profitability without developing the attachment associated with a legacy brand.

It has become easier to create a product, a business and visibility. It may have become harder to create a brand that lives in the hearts of customers for generations.

SIZE BUYS TIME

This is where size positioning becomes important: the idea that the size a business reaches changes not only its revenue but its economic character.

A large enterprise may possess greater financial resilience, diversified revenue, stronger customer relationships, broader distribution and greater capacity to absorb setbacks. These advantages create something particularly valuable. Time.

A small business facing a major technological disruption may have only a few months to respond. A large business with sufficient reserves, relationships and diversified income may have several years. That difference determines whether a business can recover, reinvent itself and survive.

Size, when supported by sound economics and resilience, can buy time. And time is the raw material from which enduring brands are built.

Size alone guarantees nothing. Large enterprises can become complacent, bureaucratic or technologically obsolete. The advantage of size must be deliberately converted into adaptability and customer loyalty.

FOR YOUR PRACTICE

1. If your largest source of business disappeared tomorrow, how many months could your practice survive while it adapted?

CHAPTER 13

Brand Equity Moves Down the Pyramid

Return to the Enablement Pyramid of Chapter 4. At the apex is the customer. Just beneath stand the practitioners and the businesses that serve customers directly: distributors, doctors, educators, retailers, consumer-product companies. Below them are the enabling layers: suppliers, vendors and the specific platforms built for one trade. Deeper still are the generic platforms on which whole economies run: operating systems, processors, cloud infrastructure, telecommunications and payment networks. At the base sit government and institutions.

The deeper the layer, the wider the activity it holds up. A practitioner serves customers. An enabling platform serves practitioners. Foundational infrastructure may serve entire industries.

The old industrial economy favoured large consumer businesses because they controlled capabilities that smaller competitors could not replicate. The modern ecosystem has made many of those capabilities available to everyone. As a result, some of the opportunity for enduring advantage has moved to the businesses that create and control the enabling layers.

A consumer company uses a marketplace; the marketplace serves thousands of consumer companies. An educator uses a learning platform; the platform serves thousands of educators. A distributor uses a transaction platform; the platform serves thousands of distributors. The individual businesses enter, grow, struggle and disappear. A successful infrastructure provider can serve successive generations of them, with recurring revenue, switching costs, network effects and deep integration. Not every platform enjoys these advantages, and even dominant infrastructure can be disrupted. But the structural opportunity is different.

The practitioner must repeatedly win customers. The road builder can benefit from the repeated activity of many practitioners.

THE NINTH PRINCIPLE · BRAND EQUITY MOVES DOWN THE PYRAMID

As shared infrastructure democratises entrepreneurship near the top of the pyramid, some of the strongest opportunities for enduring brand equity move down, towards the layers that enable economic participation.

THE PARADOX

Now comes an interesting contradiction. Businesses near the apex often have no choice but to advertise. They must be visible, recognised and chosen over alternatives, again and again. Yet they operate in crowded markets where differentiation is hard to sustain. They may build strong local brands, professional reputations or niche communities, but the multigenerational affection of the great consumer brands is harder to reach.

The infrastructure provider is in the opposite position. Its products may already be embedded in the daily work of thousands or millions of people. Its revenue may recur. Its services may be hard to replace. Because it is economically successful, management may feel little need to invest in emotional brand-building. It becomes satisfied with being useful.

But usefulness and affection are not the same thing.

The businesses that most need brands may have the shortest runways for building them. The businesses with the longest runways may feel the least need to build them.

FOR YOUR PRACTICE

1. Which platform or provider in your work do you depend on every day but feel nothing for? What would change your mind about it?

CHAPTER 14

Intel Inside, and the Google Lesson

TURNING INVISIBLE INFRASTRUCTURE INTO EMOTIONAL EQUITY

For most consumers, a microprocessor was an invisible component. They did not see it or interact with it. They bought computers, not processors.

Yet Intel recognised that its importance within the computing ecosystem could be translated into consumer recognition. The *Intel Inside* campaign turned a hidden component into a widely recognised symbol. Consumers began associating the Intel name with performance and reassurance. The company did not need to manufacture the whole computer to build a relationship with the person buying it. It built a brand around the infrastructure that made the computer work.

A company can own the road and still become emotionally meaningful to the people travelling on it.

Operating systems, cloud providers, telecommunications networks and other enabling businesses have the same opportunity. Their functional importance provides the foundation. Brand-building can add the emotional dimension: trust, reliability, empowerment, progress.

A BRAND MUST BUY RECOVERY TIME

For years, Google Search held an extraordinary place in everyday life. For millions of people, searching for information became almost synonymous with using Google. Its name entered ordinary language. Few businesses have enjoyed such frequent contact with their customers.

Yet generative AI assistants such as ChatGPT and Claude have challenged established habits of finding information. Google remains a major technology company with enormous reach and significant AI capabilities. It would be wrong to conclude that consumers have abandoned it, or that any pressure on it is simply the result of too little advertising. But the situation raises a valuable strategic question.

When a disruptive competitor emerges, how much patience will customers give the incumbent?

Suppose a competitor introduces a better experience, and the established company needs six months, a year or longer to respond. If customers have only a functional relationship with the incumbent, they may switch quickly. If they hold deep familiarity, trust and affection, they may be willing to wait. That patience has economic value. It gives management time to improve products, acquire capabilities and recover.

> THE TENTH PRINCIPLE · THE BRAND RECOVERY RUNWAY
>
> **A strong emotional brand can create a reservoir of customer goodwill that gives a business additional time to respond when its functional advantage is challenged.**

Brand loyalty cannot indefinitely compensate for an inferior product, and advertising alone cannot protect a business against technological disruption. But genuine affection may slow the speed at which customers leave. In that sense a brand is more than a marketing asset. It is a strategic reserve.

FOR YOUR PRACTICE

1. If a cheaper or cleverer alternative reached your clients next month, how many would wait for you to respond? Why?

CHAPTER 15

The Two Runways

We can now distinguish two kinds of runway, and every enduring business needs both.

MODEL 7 **The Two Runways**

THE STRUCTURAL RUNWAY

Built from financial strength, scale, distribution, technology, recurring revenue, switching costs and network effects.

How long can the business stay viable while it responds to change?

THE EMOTIONAL RUNWAY

Built from trust, familiarity, affection, reputation and repeated good experiences.

How much patience will customers give it when it struggles?

Structural strength buys time. Emotional strength encourages customers to give you time.

The two reinforce one another. A strong structural runway gives a company time to build emotional equity. Strong emotional equity can protect the structural runway during disruption. Neither is sufficient alone. A financially powerful company without customer affection may lose relevance. A beloved company without financial resilience may not survive a long crisis. The strongest enterprises deliberately build both.

FROM RECOGNITION TO AFFECTION TO ENDURANCE

MODEL 8 **Three Stages of a Brand**

RECOGNITION	Customers know the business exists. Essential for winning customers, but it does not create loyalty.
AFFECTION	Customers trust it, prefer it and return to it. The relationship extends beyond rational comparison.
ENDURANCE	The brand survives changes in technology, competition, generations and economic conditions, because affection is renewed by continuing excellence.

These stages are related but not automatic. A recognisable brand may never become loved. A loved brand may fail if it stops innovating. An enduring brand must keep renewing the reasons for its customers' affection.

WHAT THIS MEANS AT EACH LAYER

Near the apex, for the distributor, the doctor or the consumer start-up, the objective need not be to imitate the mass-market brand-building of the past. A more practical aim is a highly respected niche business with deep client relationships and strong retention, using shared infrastructure intelligently. An excellent business does not have to be a household name.

In the enabling layers, the opportunity is different. A business that improves the productivity and success of thousands of practitioners can stand for their success. Its customers may become advocates because it contributes directly to their prosperity.

At the foundation, the ambition can be larger still: to become part of the architecture of everyday economic life across generations. But indispensability today does not guarantee indispensability tomorrow. The strongest road builders must do two things at once: keep improving the road, and build enough affection that people do not abandon it the moment another road appears.

RAMESH'S ROAD · 6

The families who waited

2024. A new investing app arrives in Pune with low costs, a polished interface and an advertising budget Ramesh could never match. Some of his younger clients try it. A few leave.

Most do not. Many of his families have been with the firm for fifteen years. The firm reviewed their portfolios through two market falls, helped plan their children's education and answered the phone when a parent died. When Ramesh adds a simple online dashboard a few months later, they are still there to use it.

Ramesh will never be a household name. He does not need to be. In his city, among the families he serves, his firm has moved from recognition to affection. That bought him the months he needed.

His structural runway was modest. His emotional runway was long.

THE LONG RUNWAY IS THE REAL ASSET

We usually measure business success through revenue, profit, market share, customers and valuation. Perhaps we should pay more attention to another variable: how much time does this business possess? How long can it survive without growing, withstand competitive pressure, invest before expecting returns, and recover from a mistake before customers leave?

A business with a long runway has something that cannot be bought instantly: the opportunity to compound. It can compound financial resources, capabilities, relationships and, most importantly for a brand, trust.

The greatest brands of tomorrow may not be those that sell the most products. They may be those that enable the greatest number of people and businesses to succeed.

The road builders of tomorrow should not be content merely to collect tolls. They should aspire to build roads that people trust, value and want to keep travelling on.

THE PRINCIPLE OF THE LONG RUNWAY

Size creates the possibility of a longer runway.

A longer runway creates the opportunity for compounding.

Compounding creates the possibility of enduring brand equity.

And enduring brand equity can protect the runway when disruption arrives.

The road creates the economic opportunity. The brand creates the emotional reason to stay.

FOR YOUR PRACTICE

1. Where is your firm today: recognised, held in affection, or built to endure? What would move it one stage further?

PART VI

The Next Entrepreneurial Age

The ecosystem makes more things possible. The entrepreneur must still imagine what is worth doing.

CHAPTER 16

The Road May Belong to Someone Else

Shared infrastructure can make entrepreneurship easier. It can also create dependence. A business may build its entire customer acquisition around one marketplace, rely on a single technology platform, or depend on one provider for a critical capability.

The road remains useful, but someone else controls the tollgate.

Every distributor who has watched a referral source dry up, a commission structure change, or a software vendor discontinue a product has felt this. The road did not disappear. It simply stopped going where they had built their business to go.

MANAGING DEPENDENCE

Customer relationships may be essential

If the platform owns the relationship, the platform owns the business. Know your clients directly, by name, by goal, by history, whatever channel first brought them to you.

Brand ownership may matter

Clients should know they are dealing with you, not merely with the platform you use.

Proprietary knowledge may provide differentiation

Your methods, your frameworks and your understanding of your clients cannot be rented by a competitor.

Multiple providers may improve resilience

Two roads to the same destination are slower to build but harder to close.

Data portability may protect continuity

If you cannot take your records with you, you cannot leave. And a business that cannot leave has no bargaining power.

OWN THE OPERATING SYSTEM

By operating system we mean the way the business actually runs: how a client is onboarded, how a portfolio is reviewed, how a new team member is trained, where every client record lives, who decides what, and what the firm is called. Platforms, payment rails and vendors can all be replaced if they must be. The operating system cannot be rented back from anyone, because it is the business.

Owning the operating system is risk mitigation.

A distributor who owns it can survive a change of platform, a change of commission, a departing employee or a new regulation, because the knowledge of how the firm works sits inside the firm. A distributor who does not own it is exposed to every tollgate on every road at once.

The answer is not complete self-sufficiency. That would put you back at the start of this book, building every road yourself. The answer is to access the roads freely and own the operating system firmly.

THE ELEVENTH PRINCIPLE

Use the road. But understand who owns it, who controls access and what happens if the toll changes. Rent the roads; own the operating system.

FOR YOUR PRACTICE

1. Name the one outside provider whose change of terms would hurt you most. What is your plan if it happens?

CHAPTER 17

Build a Road for Other Distributors

A developed ecosystem creates many kinds of opportunity, but one deserves particular attention: improving the road on which other businesses depend. The best road-building ideas rarely come from people who set out to build roads. They come from practitioners who were tired of building the same road over and over again, and who realised that everyone else in their profession was building it too.

ROADS A DISTRIBUTOR CAN BUILD

Look back at the hundred practices in Chapter 6, each building its own back office. Here are some of the highways they are waiting for.

A shared operations desk

One well-run team handling transactions, servicing requests and documentation for several small practices, each of which keeps its own clients and brand.

A training path

A tested way to turn a new hire into a capable relationship manager, offered to practices too small to design one themselves.

A specialist network

Distributors who are strong in one area, such as NRI clients, retirement income or business owners, referring to one another under clear and fair terms.

Tools and templates

Review formats, onboarding checklists, client reports and calculators that every practice needs and few build well.

A succession bridge

A firm prepared to partner with or take over practices whose founders want to retire, so that their clients are not left without care, like the older distributor Ramesh met at the wedding.

Each of these is a business in its own right, subject to everything in Parts III, IV and V. It must be useful enough that practices choose it, priced so that it lasts, run with the compliance the industry requires, and trusted enough that peers will hand over part of their work. A road nobody trusts is a road nobody uses.

A ROAD PEOPLE WANT TO KEEP TRAVELLING ON

Part V adds a test that every road for other distributors must eventually pass. Being useful is not enough. The practices that use your road can rent another one. The road worth building is one they trust, value and would wait for if something better briefly appeared: the emotional runway of Chapter 15, earned from peers rather than from investors.

THREE QUESTIONS FOR ANY IDEA

How many customers can this business serve?

How many businesses can this idea enable?

How many businesses might never exist unless this idea is created?

RAMESH'S ROAD · 7

The road he did not plan to build

2025. The platform that carries most of Ramesh's transactions changes its terms. Two years ago it would have been a crisis. Now it is an inconvenience. Ramesh owns his operating system: his client records, his review method, his trained team and a firm his clients know. He has also kept a second platform running. He moves what he needs to and carries on. Chapter 16 has paid for itself.

Then something unexpected happens. Six smaller distributors in Pune, who have watched his firm change, ask how he trained his relationship manager and how his reviews are run. At first he simply shares his notes. Then he offers more: his operations team takes on their servicing work for a fee, and his training routine becomes a short course for their new hires.

Ramesh did not plan to build a road. He built one for himself, carefully enough that others could use it.

In 2001 he was the entrepreneur who had to build the road before the journey. In 2025 he is building one for others.

FOR YOUR PRACTICE

1. What problem have you solved for your own practice that most of your peers are still solving alone?

EPILOGUE

The Road That Made Other Journeys Possible

Think again about the two entrepreneurs with whom this book began. One had to construct much of the infrastructure needed for his business. The other could rely on infrastructure already available.

Now imagine a third entrepreneur. This entrepreneur does not manufacture the product or operate the vehicles. He builds a road, and a manufacturer reaches a new market, a farmer finds new buyers, and an entrepreneur discovers that a previously uneconomic idea has become viable.

The road supports activities its builder may never have anticipated. Those activities create employment and demand. They attract suppliers and encourage investment. The road has done more than transport vehicles. It has enabled economic activity.

THREE WAYS TO CREATE VALUE

Some create value through their personal work. Others organise enterprises through which many people create value. Still others build systems that allow independent enterprises to create value.

A car carries its passengers. A road enables many cars to carry their passengers.

Ramesh has travelled all three ways. He began by creating value with his own hands, built an enterprise in which others create it, and is now laying a small road for practices that are not his. Somewhere in Pune today, a young distributor is starting out with digital onboarding, a ready-made review format and a training course for her first hire. She will never know how much road was built before she arrived. That is the point of a road.

THE FINAL THOUGHT

When everyone must build their own road, entrepreneurship is expensive.

When roads are shared, entrepreneurship becomes more accessible.

And when entrepreneurs begin building roads for other entrepreneurs, the possibilities multiply.

Perhaps the greatest contribution of an ecosystem is not measured solely by the businesses it supports today. It may also be found in the enterprises that could never have existed without it.

Entrepreneurs build ecosystems.
Ecosystems create entrepreneurs.

APPENDIX

The Principles

1 THE COST OF ENTRY · CHAPTER 1

The cost of entrepreneurship is not merely the cost of the business. It also includes the cost of the ecosystem the business cannot yet access.

2 THE SHARED ROAD · CHAPTER 3

The more developed the ecosystem, the less an entrepreneur needs to build before beginning to create value.

3 ACCESS · CHAPTER 3

The modern entrepreneur need not own every capability. But must understand which capabilities are too important to leave entirely in someone else's hands.

4 TRUST · CHAPTER 5

Trust is the invisible infrastructure that allows economic relationships to scale beyond personal relationships.

5 CONFIDENCE · CHAPTER 5

Infrastructure makes entrepreneurship possible. Institutional confidence makes entrepreneurs more willing to act.

6 REACH · CHAPTER 9

The scale of your contribution is not determined only by how many customers you serve. It can also depend on how many others you enable to serve customers.

7 ENABLEMENT · CHAPTER 10

The greatest commercial opportunity may lie not in participating in every transaction, but in building something valuable that makes many transactions possible.

8 THE SHORTENING RUNWAY · CHAPTER 11

As entrepreneurial infrastructure becomes more accessible, the time required to launch a business falls, but so may the time during which its competitive advantages remain distinctive.

9 BRAND EQUITY MOVES DOWN · CHAPTER 13

As shared infrastructure democratises entrepreneurship near the top of the pyramid, some of the strongest opportunities for enduring brand equity move down, towards the layers that enable economic participation.

10 THE RECOVERY RUNWAY · CHAPTER 14

A strong emotional brand can create a reservoir of customer goodwill that gives a business additional time to respond when its functional advantage is challenged.

11 DEPENDENCE · CHAPTER 16

Use the road. But understand who owns it, who controls access and what happens if the toll changes. Rent the roads; own the operating system.

THE END

One entrepreneur must build the road before he can begin his journey. The other begins on a road someone else has built.

Every business carries two costs: the cost of serving its customers, and the cost of making that service possible. For most of history, entrepreneurs paid both. Today, shared platforms, infrastructure, standards and institutions increasingly pay the second, and in doing so they create entrepreneurs who could never have started before.

Built around the Enablement Pyramid, from the customer at its apex to the institutions at its base, and told through seventeen chapters, eleven principles, eight models and the story of Ramesh, a distributor who goes from a scooter and a bag of forms to building a road for other practices, *The Road Was Already There* shows how to stop building roads alone, why the road builders may build the most enduring brands of tomorrow, and why a brand is the emotional reason to stay on the road.

DHARMENDRA SATAPATHY

A BIRD BOOK · BUILD • INNOVATE • REIMAGINE • DELEGATE